

Beef Stew with Chestnuts

A comforting one-pot meal, serve this hearty beef stew with lots of crusty white bread.

3 lb. boneless stewing beef, cut into 4 pieces

Salt and freshly ground pepper, to taste

3½ Tbs. olive oil

1 large onion, finely chopped

2 garlic cloves, crushed

2 bay leaves

1 star anise

2 carrots, finely chopped

2 celery stalks, finely chopped

1 Tbs. tomato paste

1½ bottles red wine

18 chestnuts

1 tsp. sugar

Rub the meat with salt and pepper. In a heavy, flameproof casserole dish over medium-high heat, warm 2 Tbs. oil until hot. Add meat (be sure not to overcrowd the pot) and sear, without moving, until well-browned, 2–3 minutes per side. Remove from casserole dish.

Add 1 Tbs. oil and add the onion, garlic, bay leaves, star anise, carrots and celery and sauté, stirring occasionally scraping up any browned bits, until tender and browned, 5–7

minutes. Add salt and pepper, stir in the tomato puree, and cook, 1 minute more. Add the wine and 1¼ cups water, bring to a boil, then simmer until reduced by half, 30–40 minutes.

Meanwhile, preheat oven to 300°F.

Return the meat to the casserole dish with the vegetable-wine mixture, cover and braise in the oven until the meat is tender and nearly falling apart, about 3 hours.

If using fresh chestnuts, slice the chestnut skins open on their curved side, then boil for 5 minutes. Strain, cool, then peel and remove the brown pith. Cut in half. In a skillet over medium heat, warm the remaining ½ Tbs. oil. Add the sugar and chestnuts, and sauté until caramelized, about 3 minutes. Add to the casserole dish, then return to the oven to braise for 40 minutes more.

Serves 6.

Adapted from *Fresh from the Farmer's Market: Fall* by Alistair Hendy (Ryland, Peeters & Small, 1999).